

Chapter 11 - Stewardship

Stewarding our Treasure - Money and Time

"Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moths and vermin destroy, and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where moths and vermin do not destroy, and where thieves do not break in and steal. For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also. - Matt 6:19-21 NIV

Steward: One entrusted with managing the treasure of another, for the benefit of the owner. A steward is accountable to the owner with an expectation that there will be a return (harvest).

When his master saw that the LORD was with him and that the LORD gave him success in everything he did, Joseph found favor in his eyes and became his attendant. Potiphar put him in charge of his household, and he entrusted to his care everything he owned. From the time he put him in charge of his household and of all that he owned, the LORD blessed the household of the Egyptian because of Joseph. The blessing of the LORD was on everything Potiphar had, both in the house and in the field. - Gen 39:3-5 NIV

This, then, is how you ought to regard us: as servants of Christ and as those entrusted with the mysteries God has revealed. Now it is required that those who have been given a trust must prove faithful. - 1 Cor 4:1-2 NIV

Financial Stewardship

Abundance - Having enough to meet your needs and be generous with others

I rejoiced greatly in the Lord that at last you renewed your concern for me... Moreover, as you Philippians know, in the early days of your acquaintance with the gospel, when I set out from Macedonia, not one church shared with me in the matter of giving and receiving, except you only; for even when I was in Thessalonica, you sent me aid more than once when I was in need. Not that I desire your gifts; what I desire is that more be credited to your account. I have received full payment and have more than enough. I am amply supplied, now that I have received from Epaphroditus the gifts you sent. They are a fragrant offering, an acceptable sacrifice, pleasing to God. And my God will meet all your needs according to the riches of his glory in Christ Jesus. - Phil 4:10-19 NIV

Who is the spender? Who is the saver?

What does it look like for you to prioritize kingdom values in your financial stewardship as a couple?

Time Stewardship

In contrast to the parable of the talents, we are each allotted 24 hours daily: the workday (when many modern couples are apart), family time in the evening (when most couples are together), and sleep. We can't increase the allotment of time; we can only re-allocate it. An extra hour spent at work will mean less family time or less sleep. Chronic deprivation of sleep has well-studied health

consequences (in addition to mood disturbances). As we 'sow' into each of these sectors (work, family, sleep), we will 'reap' a harvest and there is the opportunity for either diligence or laziness. Watching cat videos at work will not yield a valuable return. At home, watching cat videos may yield a different harvest than taking a walk with your spouse or catching up during a coffee date.

Lazy hands make for poverty, but diligent hands bring wealth. He who gathers crops in summer is a prudent son, but he who sleeps during harvest is a disgraceful son. - Prov 10:4-5

The plans of the diligent lead to profit as surely as haste leads to poverty. - Prov 21:5

Are you happy with your current allocation of time between work ~ evening ~ sleep?

Unless the LORD builds the house, the builders labor in vain. Unless the LORD watches over the city, the guards stand watch in vain. In vain you rise early and stay up late, toiling for food to eat--for he grants sleep to those he loves. - Ps 127:1-2 NIV

In what ways are you tempted to overwork? In what ways are you tempted by laziness?

What do your sabbath practices look like as individuals? What may this look like as a couple?

How do your schedules differ?

How does job stress affect you? affect your relationship?

What sorts of activities at home do you find that are restorative and energize you? Reading a book? Taking a walk? Having a deep conversation?

What are your plans for how you will invest your time together?